

HSPT

High-Yield 30

30 High-Yield Questions Based on the Skills HSPT Students Ask About Most

Weighted to the Real Exam Blueprint • Full Answer Explanations

Exclusive bonus for readers of the HSPT Study Guide

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HSPT High-Yield 30

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First Edition

How This Bonus Was Built

These 30 questions are not a random sample. They are weighted to approximate the real HSPT® section proportions: 6 Verbal Skills, 5 Quantitative Skills, 6 Reading, 7 Mathematics, and 6 Language, so the mix of section time you spend here mirrors the mix you'll face in the room.

Within each section, the question types are the ones students ask about most: the analogy and synonym pace in Verbal Skills, the pattern-recognition traps in Quantitative Skills comparisons, multi-question reading passages, word-problem algebra and geometry in Mathematics, and the classic “No mistakes” option in Language — which is correct far more often than most students expect.

Every question below includes a full explanation: why the correct answer is right, and why each of the other choices is wrong. That second part is what most practice sets skip — and it's usually where the actual learning happens.

Verbal Skills

Question 1 | Synonyms

Which word means the same as “meticulous”?

- A. careless
- B. hurried
- C. thorough
- D. confused

Correct Answer: C

“Meticulous” means showing great care and attention to detail, which matches “thorough.” Choice A, “careless,” is essentially the opposite of meticulous. Choice B, “hurried,” implies rushing, which contradicts the careful, unhurried nature the word describes. Choice D, “confused,” describes a mental state unrelated to attentiveness or precision.

Question 2 | Synonyms

Which word means the same as “candid”?

- A. honest
- B. secretive
- C. cautious
- D. formal

Correct Answer: A

“Candid” means open and truthful, which matches “honest.” Choice B, “secretive,” is nearly the opposite — hiding information rather than sharing it openly. Choice C, “cautious,” describes carefulness or wariness, not truthfulness. Choice D, “formal,” describes tone or style, not honesty.

Question 3 | Analogy

Sunrise is to morning as sunset is to _____.

- A. noon
- B. midnight
- C. dawn
- D. evening

Correct Answer: D

Sunrise marks the beginning of morning, and sunset marks the beginning of evening — the relationship is event to the time period it begins. Choice A, “noon,” refers to midday and has no direct link to sunset. Choice B, “midnight,” occurs many hours after sunset, not at its start. Choice C, “dawn,” is essentially another word for sunrise, making it the wrong half of the pair.

Question 4 | Analogy

Thermometer is to temperature as scale is to ____.

- A. balance
- B. weight
- C. numbers
- D. metal

Correct Answer: B

A thermometer measures temperature, and a scale measures weight — the relationship is instrument to the quantity it measures. Choice A, “balance,” is tempting because scales achieve balance when reading a weight, but balance itself is not the quantity displayed. Choice C, “numbers,” describes the format of the readout, not what is actually being measured. Choice D, “metal,” may describe what some scales are made of, which is unrelated to their function.

Question 5 | Verbal Classification

Which word does NOT belong with the others?

- A. trumpet
- B. violin
- C. drum
- D. painting

Correct Answer: D

Trumpet, violin, and drum are all musical instruments, sharing the category “objects used to make music.” Painting is a visual artwork, not an instrument, so it does not belong with the other three.

Question 6 | Logic

Statement 1: All the students in Mr. Reyes’s class play an instrument.

Statement 2: Sofia is a student in Mr. Reyes’s class.

If the first two statements are true, the third statement is: “Sofia plays an instrument.”

- A. True
- B. False
- C. Uncertain

Correct Answer: A

Since every student in the class plays an instrument, and Sofia is a student in that class, it necessarily follows that Sofia plays an instrument — a valid deductive conclusion, so the statement is true. Choice B is incorrect because nothing in the premises contradicts the conclusion. Choice C, “uncertain,” would only apply if the first statement described just some students rather than all of them, leaving Sofia’s status ambiguous — but “all” removes that ambiguity entirely.

Quantitative Skills

Question 7 | Number Series

What number should come next in the series?

4, 9, 14, 19, 24, ____

- A. 26
- B. 27
- C. 29
- D. 30

Correct Answer: C

Each term increases by 5 ($4+5=9$, $9+5=14$, and so on), so the next term is $24+5=29$. Choice A (26) reflects a +2 step instead of +5. Choice B (27) would fit a +3 pattern, not the actual pattern shown. Choice D (30) overshoots, as if the step were +6.

Question 8 | Number Series

What number should come next in the series?

2, 6, 5, 9, 8, 12, 11, ____

- A. 14
- B. 15
- C. 10
- D. 13

Correct Answer: B

The series alternates between adding 4 and subtracting 1: $2 \rightarrow 6 (+4) \rightarrow 5 (-1) \rightarrow 9 (+4) \rightarrow 8 (-1) \rightarrow 12 (+4) \rightarrow 11 (-1) \rightarrow 15 (+4)$. Choice A (14) results from adding only 3 instead of 4. Choice C (10) reverses the final step, subtracting instead of adding. Choice D (13) results from adding only 2 instead of 4.

Question 9 | Number Manipulation

A number is tripled, then 4 is added, giving 31. What is the original number?

- A. 27
- B. 10
- C. 35
- D. 9

Correct Answer: D

Let the unknown number be x . Tripling gives $3x$, and adding 4 gives $3x+4=31$. Subtracting 4 from both sides gives $3x=27$, so $x=9$. Choice A (27) is the value of $3x$ itself — the step before dividing by 3 to isolate x , mistakenly left as the final answer. Choice B (10) results from dividing 31 by 3 directly (≈ 10.3 , rounded to 10) without first subtracting 4 to

undo the addition step. Choice C (35) results from adding 4 to 31 instead of subtracting it, reversing the correct operation.

Question 10 | Geometric Comparison

Quantity A is the area of a triangle with base 12 and height 5.

Quantity B is the area of a rectangle with length 6 and width 5.

Which quantity is greater?

- A. Quantity A is greater
- B. Quantity B is greater
- C. The two quantities are equal
- D. The relationship cannot be determined from the information given

Correct Answer: C

Quantity A = $(1/2)(12)(5) = 30$. Quantity B = $6 \times 5 = 30$. The two areas are equal. Choice A may result from forgetting the $1/2$ factor in the triangle-area formula, which would make Quantity A appear to be 60. Choice B reverses the correct comparison. Choice D is incorrect because both quantities can be calculated exactly from the information given — nothing is missing.

Question 11 | Non-Geometric Comparison

Quantity A is $3/5$ of 40.

Quantity B is 45% of 50.

Which quantity is greater?

- A. Quantity A is greater
- B. Quantity B is greater
- C. The two quantities are equal
- D. The relationship cannot be determined from the information given

Correct Answer: A

Quantity A = $(3/5) \times 40 = 24$. Quantity B = $0.45 \times 50 = 22.5$. Since $24 > 22.5$, Quantity A is greater. Choice B reverses the correct comparison. Choice C is incorrect because, while close, the values are not equal. Choice D is incorrect because both quantities can be calculated exactly from the given information.

Reading

Question 12 | Comprehension — Main Idea

Passage: For most of the 1800s, lighthouse keepers lived beside the towers they tended, climbing hundreds of steps each night to keep the lamp burning. The job demanded constant attention: a few hours of neglect could let the light go dark, putting nearby ships at risk. When the first automatic lighthouse lamps were introduced in the early 1900s, many keepers doubted the new technology, fearing it would fail during storms when it mattered most. Decades of reliable performance slowly changed their minds. By the 1960s, most lighthouses had been automated, and the profession that once required a keeper's constant presence had nearly disappeared.

What is the main idea of the passage?

- A. Lighthouse keepers were afraid of storms.
- B. Automation gradually replaced the need for full-time lighthouse keepers.
- C. Ships often crashed because lighthouse lamps went dark.
- D. Lighthouses were built primarily in the 1800s.

Correct Answer: B

The passage traces how lighthouse keeping shifted from requiring constant human presence to being automated by the 1960s, which is its central thread. Choice A describes only the keepers' initial doubt, a supporting detail rather than the main idea. Choice C states a possible consequence of neglect but is not something the passage says actually happened. Choice D is unsupported: the passage discusses lighthouse keepers during the 1800s, but it does not say that most lighthouses were built during that period.

Question 13 | Comprehension — Detail

(Refers to the same passage as the question above.)

Based on the passage, why were keepers initially skeptical of automatic lamps?

- A. They doubted the lamps would work reliably during severe weather.
- B. They believed the new lamps were too expensive to install.
- C. They wanted to keep their jobs and opposed any change.
- D. They had never seen an automatic lamp in operation before.

Correct Answer: A

The passage directly states keepers "fear[ed] it would fail during storms when it mattered most," supporting this choice. Choice B introduces cost concerns never mentioned in the passage. Choice C assumes a motive (job protection) the passage never states, even though it might seem plausible. Choice D is too literal — the passage specifies a fear about storm performance, not simple unfamiliarity.

Question 14 | Vocabulary in Context

(Refers to the same passage as the question above.)

As used in the passage, the word "demanded" most nearly means:

- A. requested politely
- B. avoided
- C. questioned
- D. required

Correct Answer: D

In context, “the job demanded constant attention” means the job required or necessitated constant attention. Choice A softens the meaning too much — “demanded” implies necessity, not a polite request. Choice B is nearly the opposite of the intended meaning. Choice C does not fit — the job wasn’t “questioning” attention, it was requiring it.

Question 15 | Comprehension — Main Idea

Passage: When Marcus joined the debate team, he assumed the hardest part would be memorizing facts and statistics. He spent hours each week building a library of evidence for every possible topic. During his first real match, though, his opponent calmly dismantled his strongest argument in under a minute, exposing a flaw Marcus had never noticed. Stunned, Marcus lost that round badly. Rather than quitting, he began attending every practice early to study how experienced debaters questioned each other’s logic, not just their facts. Within a season, Marcus was known less for what he memorized and more for how sharply he could think on his feet.

What is the main idea of the passage?

- A. Marcus quit the debate team after losing his first match.
- B. Memorizing statistics is the most important skill in debate.
- C. Marcus learned that clear thinking mattered more than memorized facts.
- D. Marcus’s opponent was unfairly prepared for their match.

Correct Answer: C

The passage shows Marcus shifting his focus from memorization to sharpening his reasoning after a loss revealed its limits — the passage’s central arc. Choice A directly contradicts the passage, which says he did not quit. Choice B is the opposite of what the passage ultimately concludes. Choice D introduces an idea the passage never suggests — the opponent’s skill was simply stronger in the moment, not unfair.

Question 16 | Comprehension — Inference

(Refers to the same passage as the question above.)

It can be inferred that Marcus’s opponent won the first match mainly because that opponent:

- A. was better at identifying weaknesses in an argument’s logic.
- B. had memorized more facts than Marcus.
- C. spoke for a longer amount of time.
- D. had studied Marcus’s evidence beforehand.

Correct Answer: A

The passage says the opponent “dismantled his strongest argument ... exposing a flaw,” which points to a strength in logical analysis rather than raw fact recall. Choice B is not supported — the passage never compares how much each

competitor memorized. Choice C introduces a detail never mentioned. Choice D assumes prior knowledge of Marcus's specific evidence, which the passage does not indicate.

Question 17 | Vocabulary in Context

(Refers to the same passage as the question above.)

As used in the passage, the word “dismantled” most nearly means:

- A. politely questioned
- B. thoroughly refuted
- C. quietly ignored
- D. slightly improved

Correct Answer: B

“Dismantled” in this context describes systematically taking apart and defeating the argument, matching “thoroughly refuted.” Choice A undersells the strength of the action — the passage describes a decisive defeat, not a gentle question. Choice C contradicts the passage, since the opponent actively engaged with and defeated the argument rather than ignoring it. Choice D is nearly the opposite of the intended meaning.

Mathematics

Question 18 | Percent

A jacket originally priced at \$80 is on sale for 25% off. What is the sale price?

- A. \$55
- B. \$65
- C. \$70
- D. \$60

Correct Answer: D

25% of \$80 is $0.25 \times 80 = \$20$; subtracting the discount gives $\$80 - \$20 = \$60$. Choice A (\$55) subtracts too much, as if the discount were about 31%. Choice B (\$65) reflects subtracting only \$15, about a 19% discount. Choice C (\$70) reflects subtracting just \$10, about a 12.5% discount instead of the correct 25%.

Question 19 | Ratio & Proportion

A recipe uses 3 cups of flour for every 2 cups of sugar. If a baker uses 9 cups of flour, how many cups of sugar are needed to keep the same ratio?

- A. 4
- B. 5
- C. 6
- D. 7

Correct Answer: C

Since 9 cups of flour is 3 times as much as the original 3 cups, the sugar must also be scaled by 3: $2 \times 3 = 6$ cups. Choice A (4) results from dividing 9 by 2 (the sugar's original amount) instead of by 3 (the flour's original amount) to find the scale factor: $9 \div 2 = 4.5$, rounded down to 4. Choice B (5) results from adding the scale factor ($9 \div 3 = 3$) to the original sugar amount instead of multiplying by it: $2 + 3 = 5$. Choice D (7) results from adding the ratio's total parts ($3 + 2 = 5$) to the original sugar amount instead of scaling proportionally: $2 + 5 = 7$.

Question 20 | Order of Operations

What is the value of $6 + 4 \times (9 - 5) \div 2$?

- A. 14
- B. 10
- C. 16
- D. 20

Correct Answer: A

Following order of operations: first the parentheses ($9 - 5 = 4$), then multiplication ($4 \times 4 = 16$), then division ($16 \div 2 = 8$), and finally addition ($6 + 8 = 14$). Choice B (10) results from adding 6 and 4 first (violating order of operations) and stopping there, without carrying out the remaining $\times$ and $\div$ steps. Choice C (16) stops after the multiplication step and ignores

the division and addition. Choice D (20) results from that same left-to-right slip carried further: $6+4=10$ first, then $\times(9-5)=40$, then $\div 2=20$ — order of operations skipped throughout.

Question 21 | Algebra

Solve for x : $5x - 3 = 2x + 12$

- A. 3
- B. 12
- C. 15
- D. 5

Correct Answer: D

Subtracting $2x$ from both sides gives $3x-3=12$. Adding 3 to both sides gives $3x=15$, so $x=5$. Choice A (3) results from dividing 15 by 5 instead of by 3 — using the original coefficient from “ $5x$ ” rather than the simplified coefficient from “ $3x$.” Choice B (12) results from subtracting 3 from 15 instead of dividing by 3, treating the coefficient as if it were an added term rather than a multiplier: $15-3=12$. Choice C (15) is the value of $3x$ itself, mistakenly left un-divided by 3.

Question 22 | Geometry

A trapezoid has parallel sides of length 6 and 10, and a height of 4. What is its area?

- A. 20
- B. 32
- C. 24
- D. 64

Correct Answer: B

The area of a trapezoid is $(1/2)(b_1+b_2)(h) = (1/2)(6+10)(4) = (1/2)(16)(4) = 32$. Choice A (20) comes from using only the base of 10 and forgetting to add the base of 6 before halving: $(1/2)(10)(4)=20$. Choice C (24) comes from mistakenly doubling the smaller base instead of adding both different bases: $(1/2)(6+6)(4)=24$. Choice D (64) comes from forgetting the $1/2$ factor entirely: $(6+10)(4)=64$.

Question 23 | Geometry — Pythagorean Theorem

A right triangle has legs of length 9 and 12. What is the length of the hypotenuse?

- A. 13
- B. 18
- C. 15
- D. 21

Correct Answer: C

By the Pythagorean theorem, $\text{hypotenuse}^2 = 9^2+12^2 = 81+144 = 225$, so the hypotenuse $= \sqrt{225} = 15$. Choice D (21) comes from simply adding the two legs ($9+12$), ignoring the Pythagorean relationship entirely. Choices A (13) and B (18) do not correspond to any calculation using the given legs — they are plausible-looking numbers designed to tempt someone unsure of the correct formula.

Question 24 | Numbers & Estimation

Which of the following is closest to the value of 597×31 ?

- A. 18,000
- B. 1,800
- C. 6,000
- D. 60,000

Correct Answer: A

Rounding 597 to 600 and 31 to 30 gives an estimate of $600 \times 30 = 18,000$, which is closest to the actual product. Choices B, C, and D are not reasonable estimates for 597×31 .

Language

Question 25 | Capitalization

Identify the segment that contains an error. If there is no error, choose “No mistakes.”

- A. My uncle, who lives in Denver,
- B. is planning to visit us next Summer
- C. after his conference ends.
- D. No mistakes

Correct Answer: B

Segment B incorrectly capitalizes “Summer.” Seasons (spring, summer, fall, winter) are not proper nouns and should not be capitalized unless they start a sentence or are part of a proper title. Segment A is correctly punctuated, with commas properly setting off the nonessential clause “who lives in Denver.” Segment C contains no errors. Since an actual error exists in segment B, “No mistakes” is not correct.

Question 26 | Usage

Identify the segment that contains an error. If there is no error, choose “No mistakes.”

- A. The bus arrived early,
- B. so the students had extra time
- C. to review they're notes before the test.
- D. No mistakes

Correct Answer: C

Segment C incorrectly uses “they’re” (a contraction of “they are”) where the possessive form “their” is required to describe notes belonging to the students. Segment A is correctly punctuated with a comma before the coordinating conjunction “so.” Segment B contains no errors. Because segment C contains an error, “No mistakes” is incorrect.

Question 27 | Usage

Identify the segment that contains an error. If there is no error, choose “No mistakes.”

- A. Neither of the boys
- B. have finished
- C. their homework yet.
- D. No mistakes

Correct Answer: B

Segment B contains a subject-verb agreement error. “Neither” is a singular pronoun, so the verb should be “has finished,” not “have finished.” Segment A correctly introduces the singular subject “Neither of the boys.” Segment C is correct. Since segment B contains a genuine error, “No mistakes” is incorrect.

Question 28 | Spelling

Identify the segment that contains an error. If there is no error, choose “No mistakes.”

- A. The commitee will announce
- B. the winner of the contest
- C. sometime next week.
- D. No mistakes

Correct Answer: A

Segment A misspells “committee,” which requires a double “m,” double “t,” and double “e” (c-o-m-m-i-t-t-e-e). Segments B and C contain no spelling errors. Because segment A contains a clear spelling error, “No mistakes” is incorrect.

Question 29 | Composition

Which is the best way to combine these two sentences?

“The team practiced every day after school. They wanted to win the championship.”

- A. The team practiced every day after school, they wanted to win the championship.
- B. The team practiced every day after school because they wanted to win the championship.
- C. The team practiced every day after school, but they wanted to win the championship.
- D. The team practiced every day after school, and it was because they wanted to win the championship, so that's why.

Correct Answer: B

Choice B combines the two ideas clearly and logically using “because” to show the cause-and-effect relationship between practicing and wanting to win. Choice A creates a comma splice by joining two independent clauses with only a comma. Choice C uses “but,” a contrast word, which misrepresents the relationship between the two ideas — there is no contrast here, only a cause and its motivation. Choice D is needlessly wordy and repetitive (“it was because ... so that's why”), which weakens clarity rather than improving it.

Question 30 | Punctuation

Identify the segment that contains an error. If there is no error, choose “No mistakes.”

- A. Before the game started,
- B. the coach reminded the team to stay focused
- C. and play as a unit.
- D. No mistakes

Correct Answer: D

The sentence is correctly punctuated throughout: segment A closes the introductory clause with a comma, segment B connects the infinitive phrase “to stay focused” to the verb without an unnecessary comma, and segment C completes the sentence with the second parallel infinitive “play as a unit,” correctly joined by “and” without a comma. Since no segment contains an error, “No mistakes” is the correct choice — a reminder that not every real-test sentence has a planted error, and confidently choosing “No mistakes” when a sentence truly is correct is just as important as spotting real mistakes elsewhere.